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Making Headlines

ASSAM CHIEF MINISTER HIMANTA BISWA SARMA DISPLAYS AN UNUSUAL PENCHANT FOR STAYING IN THE NEWS VIA HIS POLARISING ACTIONS AND BACKDOOR OPERATIONS. IT IS HELPING HIM FORGE A PLACE IN THE PUBLIC CONSCIOUSNESS ACROSS INDIA

By Kaushik Deka

On February 14, while the world was celebrating the day of love, a massive controversy had erupted in Maharashtra erupt over a newspaper advertisement by the Assam government. Carrying a prominent picture of Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, the ad appealed to the masses to visit the Bhimashankar Temple on February 18 to celebrate Mahashivratri. There was nothing wrong in inviting people to the ancient Shiva temple lying in the foothills of Dakini Hill, near Guwahati, but the ad also claimed that the shrine was the sixth of the 12 sacred *jyotirlingas* (divine halos of light that connect to stone lingams on Earth through which Lord Shiva is said to have emerged) found across the country.

Why did the Assam government's claim evoke such sharp reactions in Maharashtra? It was because the Bhimashankar temple in Pune is usually considered the sixth *jyotirlinga*. Confronted with that criticism, Sarma countered, "We have not invented a new *jyotirlinga*. There is mention of Kamrupeshwar and Dakini hills in the Shiva Puran. If politicians in Maharashtra are upset, they should show their resentment to Odisha and Jharkhand too, for temples with the same name exist there too."

Regardless of the outcome of the debate, what the *jyotirlinga* controversy did demonstrate was a trademark tendency in the Assam chief minister's political career—creating disruptions in a regular discourse. From